

The Heir of Birchmere:

Long ago in the Kingdom of Birchmere, the good King Birch decided that he was getting too old to be the king. He wanted to find an heir to the throne who was ready to learn the royal ways. The king decided to travel throughout the kingdom, looking for a boy who was honest, fair, and most of all, respectful. King Birch thought that if a boy was respectful to his own parents, he would be honorable by nature, and would make a good king. In the countryside of Birchmere, there lived a farmer and his four sons. One very rainy night, as the boys were sitting by the fire, they heard a scratching sound at the door. When they opened the door, a cold, wet rabbit hopped slowly into the house and shook its soaked fur. "Poor rabbit," the father said. "He must have gotten out of his hutch. Who will take this rabbit back out to the barn on this cold, miserable night?" Each of the sons made an excuse to stay in by the warm fire. "I do not want to get wet," said one boy. "I have other things to do," said another boy. "I will catch a cold if I go out in this weather," said the third boy. The youngest son picked up the rabbit and headed for the door. "I will take the rabbit back to the hutch, Father," he said. "You stay in where it is warm and dry." And the boy walked out to the barn with the shivering rabbit. As the boy opened the barn door, he was shocked to find King Birch in the barn waiting for him. "Your Highness!" the boy exclaimed as he bowed his head and fell to his knees in respect. "Rise to your feet, boy," said the King. "I have chosen you to be my heir to the throne. I have traveled all through the lands in search of a boy who shows true respect for his parents. I have tested each boy with this wet rabbit, and each time, the boys said inside while their fathers or mothers came out in the rain to return the rabbit to the hutch. You are the first boy to put your own comfort aside and insist your father stay warm and dry. For that kindness and respect you have shown, you will become the leader over all this land." From that day forward, the youngest son and his father lived happily in the castle with the king.